

PERSONAL CONNECTION: STUDENT LOAN IGNORANCE

When 17-year-old me arrived on my college campus, I had no clue how I was paying for it. Literally no idea. I did not realize I was borrowing over \$6,000 a year to pay for my experience. Had I known, I probably would have spent far more time studying and far less time choosing which “vintage” rock ‘n’ roll shirt would make me look the coolest.¹⁹

I don’t want to put all the blame on other people, but I feel like someone along the way should have made the terms of my loans clear to me. Paying back \$25,000 took me about eight years and was a huge burden on my budget. That said, it could have been worse. Because I knew nothing about my loans and probably would have signed anything, they could have been \$35,000, \$55,000, or more. If that were the case, I would still be paying them off and my life would be on a much more difficult trajectory today.

Take ownership of your student loans and be involved in the process. Before you choose a school, you should know exactly how much it is going to cost and what the payments are going to look like when you have graduated. Don’t be like me and wait to learn this information years after you have already agreed to a decision that is going to be profoundly influential in your life.

¹⁹ It turns out “none of them” was the answer to that riddle.